rounds of ammunition, 122,332 explosive devices, and a large volume of other war material in Kashmir, and 4,536 incidents of violence had occurred in 2001 alone.[116] The parliament attack by Kashmir-focused and Pakistan-based groups unshackled India from restraining to use force. On 14 December 2001, India launched Operation Parakram and mobilised its armed forces, all set to undertake offensive action against Pakistan. Lasting ten-months until October 2002, Operation Parakram did not end in all out war. Powell's shuttle diplomacy between New Delhi and Islamabad helped contain the situation.[117]

An India-Pakistan war would have undermined the US initiative in Afghanistan (in addition to destabilising the region). With Pakistan having changed its policy and cooperating with the US, it was important for Washington to ensure that fresh Indian pressure on Pakistan would not derail the ongoing war efforts in Afghanistan. Operation Parakram reflected India's willingness to undertake military brinkmanship with Pakistan. New Delhi hoped that Washington would support its cause given its own preoccupation with terrorism. This was made clear by Jaswant Singh to the then US ambassador to India, Robert Blackwill, and US special envoy to Afghanistan, James Dobbins, both of whom were in New Delhi five days after the parliament attack. Blackwill gave a very sympathetic ear to the Indian leadership, but was gravely concerned about the situation in private, and was planning to use his leeway with Jaswant Singh and Brajesh Mishra to deescalate the situation. Dobbins, however, politely but bluntly, began reducing India's expectations of increasing its profile in Afghanistan in light of the fresh tension with Pakistan. Though India readily accepted Karzai to stay on board with the US at Bonn, it did not mean an automatic US approval of a heavy Indian presence in Afghanistan. Instead, as Dobbins clarified, India was to be kept at a distance lest it unsettled Pakistan.[118] Satinder Lambah, Dobbins' Indian counterpart, expectedly, was disappointed.[119]

The debate over India's military engagement in Afghanistan ended in the light of Operation Parakram. Security donors to Afghanistan decided, at a conference in Geneva in April 2002, that all regional actors must be kept out of the security domain.[120] India's last-ditch effort in Geneva (made by Lambah and a senior Indian army general) to convince Dobbins about letting India raise the Afghan National Army made little impact.[121] Gharekhan, former Indian representative to